THE ANGLO-DUTCH WARS

Although the theater of action sometimes switched to the Mediterranean, the coast of West Africa, and North America, the most destructive fleet engagements of the Anglo-Dutch wars took place in the North Sea and the English Channel. The three wars that England and the Dutch fought between 1652 and 1674 were forgotten when the two states allied to face the threat of the expansionist policies of Louis XIV's France.

KEY

- England
- United Provinces
- Spanish Netherlands
- Borders 1650
- Dutch convoy route
- Dutch victory
- English victory
- Inconclusive battle





Badge of wealth
The Dutch East India Company, the Vereenigde Oost-Indische Compagnie, founded in 1602, controlled the highly lucrative trade routes to the Spice Islands of Indonesia. VOC, the company's monogram, appears on this 17th-century seal.

of the inflation of firepower that the cannonade in the Four Days Battle, fought off the North Foreland during the Second Anglo-Dutch War in 1666, was audible to strollers in London's Hyde Park, at a distance of some 80 miles (120 km) from the battle.

Command and control needed improvement as well as armament. The top commanders on the English side, such as Robert Blake and George Monck, were land officers sent to sea, while Dutch commanders were seamen born and bred—Michiel de Ruyter and the Tromps began their careers as cabin boys. But both sides initially depended heavily on merchant captains forced to bring their ships into temporary naval service. These not surprisingly often proved unreliable in the heat of battle. Thus there was swift progress toward creating a body of dedicated senior ratings and naval officers—in England a mix of "tarpaulins" bred to the sea and "gentleman commanders"—to man fleets ideally consisting entirely of warships.

In 1653 the English navy's famous Articles of War were first instituted, prescribing severe punishments for officers who failed to obey orders or who hung back from a fight. The systematic adoption of the line of battle, initially by the English, was intended to improve discipline and organization in combat, as well as making it less likely ships would be hit by "friendly fire." Although battles still tended to disintegrate into general mêlées, the line of battle gave commanders some chance of effecting coherent maneuvers.

ESCALATING DEMANDS OF WAR

Both sides struggled to meet the material and financial demands of naval warfare. The docks at Chatham were by far the largest industrial enterprise in England, and a sea battle used up shot and powder at a phenomenal rate. A fleet of ships contained as many people as a major contemporary town—Norwich in England or Haarlem in Holland, for example—posing daunting problems of supply of food and water.

Racked by political conflicts, both states struggled to keep up with these demands. England had just been torn apart by civil war, the king executed and replaced by the Lord Protector, Oliver Cromwell. The Restoration of the monarchy under Charles II came between the First and the Second Anglo-Dutch Wars. When the monarchy's money ran out during the second war, sailors were not paid and supplies could not be bought. Sustaining warfare was made more difficult because it interrupted trade, both through enemy commerce raiding and the transfer of seamen from merchant to naval service, thus cutting into the revenues available.

The difficulties experienced by both sides in financing the war effort helped make these conflicts, despite their savagery, totally indecisive. Yet a fundamental shift in the naval balance of power was under way. Before the end of the century, the once dominant Dutch would become the junior partner of the English in their joint wars against the French.

Holmes's Bonfire
In August 1666 the British fleet lay off the Dutch coast and watched as a small squadron of frigates and fireships under Sir Robert Holmes raided the town of Terschelling. They not only burned the town, but also destroyed 140 merchantmen.

